

THE TENANT'S

Guide

Questions to ask — and be ready to answer — before you sign a lease. It's a two-way street: clear, honest, and built to protect you.

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Questions to Ask the Landlord

Rent History & Future Increases

How much has the rent been raised in each of the last 3–5 years, and how often?

Why it matters: Shows you the real trend, not just a verbal promise.

What is your plan for rent increases over the next 1–3 years?

Why it matters: Lets you budget ahead and spot a landlord who won't commit to anything, which is itself useful information.

Would you be willing to cap the increase or put the increase schedule in writing as a lease addendum?

Why it matters: A verbal answer isn't enforceable. Getting a cap or schedule into the lease protects you if the answer changes after you move in.

Is the security deposit negotiable, and exactly what conditions cause it to be withheld?

Why it matters: Clarifies expectations up front and gives you something to point to at move-out if there's a dispute.

Are there other recurring fees (parking, pet, amenity, admin, utility billing), and can those change during the lease?

Why it matters: Fees outside "rent" can still add up and are sometimes not covered by rent-increase limits.

What is the late fee amount and grace period?

Why it matters: Confirms the real cost of a late payment and whether there's any cushion.

Home Systems & Condition

How old is the HVAC system, and when was it last serviced?

Why it matters: An aging or unserviced system is more likely to fail, often in extreme weather conditions.

Has the HVAC ever broken down here? How was it handled, and how long did repairs take?

Why it matters: Tells you how responsive the landlord actually is when something big fails, not just what they promise.

How old is the water heater? Any history of leaks, flooding, or replacement?

Why it matters: Water heater failures can cause real property damage — worth knowing so you're mindful of what you store near it.

What is the age and condition of the roof, plumbing, electrical panel, and major appliances?

Why it matters: Big-ticket items that are original or old are more likely to need repair during your tenancy.

Is there a home warranty or service contract covering major systems?

Why it matters: *Affects how fast repairs happen and who pays.*

Any known history of mold, pests, or water intrusion? Was it professionally remediated?

Why it matters: *You're looking out for possible health and safety issues.*

Do you carry insurance on the property, and what does it typically cover?

Why it matters: *Landlord insurance usually covers the building itself, not your belongings — good to know so you can decide if renters insurance makes sense for you.*

Maintenance & Repairs

Who handles maintenance requests — you directly, or a property manager?

Why it matters: *Tells you who to call and how many layers are between you and a fix.*

What is the typical response time for non-emergency vs. emergency repairs?

Why it matters: *Sets realistic expectations and gives you a benchmark if repairs later run slow.*

Is there a 24/7 emergency contact for things like no heat, no water, or a gas leak?

Why it matters: *Critical for true emergencies — confirm it exists before you need it.*

Who is responsible for lawn care, snow removal, pest control, and any solar costs?

Why it matters: *Avoids surprise costs or chores you assumed were included — some landlords pass solar costs to tenants separately, so it's worth confirming upfront.*

Past Tenants & Track Record

Why did the previous tenant(s) move out?

Why it matters: *A pattern of short stays, or the same complaint repeating, is a red flag worth digging into.*

What have past tenants complained about most while living here?

Why it matters: *Direct insight into recurring problems the listing won't mention.*

How long does the average tenant stay in this unit?

Why it matters: *Long average tenancies usually suggest a landlord who's easy to work with and a property in good shape.*

Have you ever had to evict a tenant here? Would you be willing to share why?

Why it matters: *Not always answered, but worth asking — the response (or refusal) tells you something.*

Lease Terms & Policies

What is the renewal process, and how much notice do you give before a rent increase or non-renewal?

Why it matters: *Affects how much lead time you'll have to plan a move or negotiate.*

Is subletting or adding a roommate allowed, and under what process?

Why it matters: *Matters if your situation could change during the lease term.*

What is the policy and cost for breaking the lease early?

Why it matters: *Know your exit cost before you're locked in, in case a job or life change comes up.*

Are there restrictions on modifications, like painting or hanging art or shelving?

Why it matters: *Avoids deposit deductions later for reasonable, common changes.*

What is the pet policy, including breed/weight limits and pet rent or deposit?

Why it matters: *Confirms whether your pet is welcome and what it will actually cost.*

Utilities & Costs

Which utilities are included in rent, and which are the tenant's responsibility?

Why it matters: *Directly affects your true monthly housing cost.*

What have average monthly utility costs been for this unit?

Why it matters: *Helps you budget accurately instead of guessing.*

Is the property on municipal water/sewer or well/septic, and are there any known issues with either?

Why it matters: *Well and septic systems carry maintenance responsibilities many renters don't expect.*

Neighborhood & Safety

Are there any planned developments, construction, or zoning changes nearby?

Why it matters: *Could affect noise, parking, views, or your daily commute during your lease.*

How would you describe the neighborhood in terms of noise, safety, and parking?

Why it matters: *Compare the landlord's answer to your own research and a walk-through at different times of day.*

Landlord Background

Do you own the property outright, or is it financed? Is there any risk of foreclosure?

Why it matters: *A property at risk of foreclosure could end your tenancy unexpectedly, regardless of your lease.*

How many other rental properties do you manage?

Why it matters: *A very large portfolio may mean slower personal attention; a single-property landlord may mean less formal process — neither is automatically better, but it's useful context.*

How would you describe your management style as a landlord?

Why it matters: *Gives you a sense of how the property is managed and what to expect in terms of communication.*

Be Ready to Answer — What Landlords Will Ask You

Proof of income: pay stubs (last 2–3), an offer/employment letter, or two years of tax returns if self-employed.

Why they ask: *Most landlords want to see income at roughly 2.5–3x the monthly rent.*

Employment verification: employer name, HR/manager contact, and length of employment.

Why they ask: *Confirms income is stable, not just a single pay stub snapshot.*

Credit check authorization: consent to run a credit report, and possibly an application fee.

Why they ask: *Used to gauge payment reliability — know your score ahead of time so there are no surprises.*

Rental history and references: contact info for your current and prior landlord(s).

Why they ask: *A track record of on-time rent and lease compliance is one of the strongest signals landlords look for.*

Reason for moving: a short, honest explanation.

Why they ask: *Helps the landlord understand your situation and timeline.*

Background check authorization: consent for a background/eviction history check.

Why they ask: *Standard in most applications; know what's on your record before you apply.*

Occupants and pets: names/ages of everyone living in the unit, plus pet details (breed, weight, vaccination records).

Why they ask: *Affects lease terms, deposits, and whether the unit is a fit.*

Move-in date and desired lease length: a clear target date and preferred term (e.g., 12 months).

Why they ask: *Helps the landlord plan around their vacancy and other applicants.*

Co-signer/guarantor info: contact and financial info for a co-signer, if your income alone doesn't qualify.

Why they ask: *Common ask for first-time renters or thinner credit files.*

Emergency contact: name and phone number of someone not living with you.

Why they ask: *Standard on most lease applications.*

Renters insurance: are you willing to carry a policy covering your belongings and liability?

Why they ask: *Many landlords require it — their own insurance covers the building, not your personal property.*

Quick Tips

This is a two-way conversation. A good landlord will expect thoughtful questions — asking them is a positive signal, not a red flag.

Get key answers in writing. Anything important the landlord tells you verbally (rent increase plans, repair timelines, included utilities) should be added to the lease as an addendum before you sign.

Bring this guide to the showing, or send the top questions by email first so you have a written record of the answers.

Watch for vague or evasive answers, especially on rent history, past tenant complaints, and system age — these are the questions landlords are most likely to soften.

Verify what you can independently: county property records show ownership and mortgage info, and some cities have public rental registries.

Have your own documents ready (pay stubs, ID, references) so you can move quickly once you find the right home — good units go fast.



Questions?

Let's get started.

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